

What Is Life



GOPINATH R

Chapter 1 – Where It Begins

The sky looked blue.

Night slowly came down.

A cool wind passed through the trees, and a few dry leaves fell onto the road.

Near a small tea shop, a group of boys stood together, holding small glasses of tea.

One boy ask casually, "Bro, which college are you going to join?"

Another boy laugh and say, "I don't even know if I will pass."

Someone from behind added, "My dad said first join college, then we'll talk about everything else."

One boy say excitedly, "I'm going to buy a laptop as soon as college starts."

Suddenly, one voice come loudly, "Bro... a girl proposed to me!"

Everyone turn toward him.

One boy ask, "And?"

The boy smile and say, "I accepted."

For one second, everything become silent.

Then all the boys shout together,
"AAAAAAA!"

Laughter filled the place.

Among them stood Rohan.

Rohan's phone rang.

The laughter slowly stopped.

He looked at the screen.
It was his mother.

Rohan answer the call and say,
"Hello, ma,"





His mother asked, "Where are you now? If you come late, I won't open the door."

Rohan smiled and said, "I'm on the way, Ma."

The call ended.

Rohan looked at his friends and said, "I have to go now."

One boy replied, "Okay, bro. Tea again tomorrow."

Rohan sat on his friend's bike.

The engine started.

They rode away, leaving the tea shop behind.

Rohan was 18 years old.

His school life was coming to an end.
College life was waiting for him.

His life felt simple.

Friends.
Laughter.
Small moments.

Rohan believed life had no limits.
In his mind, his future looked clear.

A big house.
A BMW car.
Traveling to many places.
Exploring new cities.
Becoming a great person.

He didn't think about pain.
He didn't think about responsibility.

Right now, life felt open.
Like the sky above him.
Rohan lay on his bed that night and looked at the ceiling.

Tomorrow felt bright.

Chapter 2 – The Phone Call

One day, the train slowly came to a stop.
Rohan got down and looked around.

This was his native place.
The station felt familiar, but something felt wrong.

Rohan put his hand into his pocket.
Nothing.

He checked again.
Still nothing.

His heartbeat slowly increased.
Rohan opened his bag quickly.

Books.
Clothes.
No phone.
No wallet.

He sat down on a bench and took a deep breath.
He tell himself, "It's okay... just one call."

Rohan stood up and walked toward a few people standing nearby.

He say softly, "Anna, can I use your mobile? Just one call."

The man looked at him for a second and shook his head.

Rohan tried another person.
He say, "Brother, please... I just need to call my friend."

The man stepped back and say, "Sorry,"
then walked away.

Rohan tried again.

Some people ignored him.
Some avoided him.
Some looked at him with doubt.

After a few minutes, Rohan walked back and sat on the bench.

He was in his own place,
but he felt completely alone.

He looked around the station.

People were coming and going.
No one noticed him.

At that moment,
a voice spoke near him.
"Problem?"

Rohan looked up.

A man was standing there.

Simple shirt.
Office bag on his shoulder.
Tired eyes.
This was Varun.



Rohan hesitate for a moment, then say, "I lost my phone."
"I just need to make one call."

Varun looked at him carefully.
For a second, he didn't speak.
Then he took out his phone and say, "Tell me the number."

Rohan felt surprised.
He ask, "Really?"

Varun nodded.

Rohan told the number.
The call connected.
Rohan say, "Hello?"

After a moment, his face changed.
He say, "Bro, I'm at the station."
"Yes... I lost my phone."
"Okay, okay."
He ended the call and looked at Varun.

Rohan smile with relief and say, "Thank you."
"Thank you so much."

Varun smile a little and say, "It's okay."
"Someone will come?"

Rohan reply, "Yes."
"My friend is on the way."

They stood there for a few seconds.

A train passed by.
Varun checked the time.
He say, "I should go."

Rohan quickly say, "Thanks again, anna."

Varun nodded and walked away.

After some time, a bike stopped near the bench.
His friend shout, "Bro! What happened?"

Rohan smile and say, "Long story."

He got on the bike and left.
From a distance, Varun watched Rohan go.
Then Varun turned around and walked in the opposite direction.

The story slowly stayed with Varun.



Chapter 3 – Varun’s Life

Varun woke up early in the morning.

The room was silent.
No alarm sound.
No voice.
No movement.

He lived alone in a small rented room, far away from his hometown.
No family.
No friends nearby.

Only him.

Varun sat on the bed for a few seconds and looked around.
Nothing had changed.
Same walls.
Same silence.

He got up, washed his face, and got ready for work.

A small breakfast.
Simple clothes.

Before leaving, he checked his phone.
One message.

From Priya.
"Good morning."

Varun smiled a little.

He reply,
"Good morning."

That one message was enough to make his morning feel light.

Varun worked in a private company.
His monthly salary was ₹35,000.

For some people, it sounded okay.
For Varun, it was just enough.

Enough to pay rent.
Enough to send money home.
Enough to survive.

Not enough to dream.

Office life moved slowly.
Emails.
Files.
Meetings.

Hours passed without feeling.



At 4:30 p.m., his phone rang.

It was his mother.
She ask, "Why don't you call?"
"When will you come home?"

Varun looked at the screen for a second.
He say, "Soon, ma."

She stayed quiet for a moment.
Then the call ended.
Varun put the phone down and went back to work.

That night, Varun returned to his room.
The room welcomed him with silence again.

He sat on the bed and opened his phone.

Priya called.

She say, "Varun, today my manager gave me extra work."
"I'm very tired."

Varun listen quietly.

He didn't talk about his day.
He didn't talk about his stress.

He say, "It's okay."
"You'll be fine."

She laughed softly.

After the call ended, Varun kept the phone aside.
He lay down and stared at the ceiling.

Once, he had dreams too.
Traveling.
A better life.
Doing something he liked.

But life changed.

Responsibilities came first.
Dreams slowly moved away.

Sometimes, Varun felt like he was living a life chosen by others.
Not by him.
He closed his eyes slowly.

Tomorrow would be the same.



Chapter 4 – Confessions at Dusk

That day felt different for Varun.

He couldn't focus on his work.
His mind felt heavy, restless.

Files were open in front of him,
but his thoughts were somewhere else.

Again and again, one thought came.

Today.

In the evening, Varun met Priya.

They sat near a small shop by the road.

People moved around.
Vehicles passed by.
Life was happening everywhere.

Priya talked about her day.
She smile and say,
"Today was very busy. My manager didn't even give me time to breathe."

Varun listened quietly.
He nodded.
But his heart was beating fast.

After a few minutes, he took a deep breath.
He look at Priya and say,
"Priya... I need to tell you something."

She looked at him and ask,
"What?"

Varun's hands were shaking a little.
He swallow his fear and say,
"I like you. No... I love you."

The noise around them felt slow.

Priya didn't speak immediately.
She looked away.

After a few seconds, she say softly,
"Varun... you are a good person. But I only see you as a friend."

Those words hit him hard.
Varun nodded slowly.
He force a small smile and say,
"Okay."

Nothing more.
No questions.
No arguments.

He stood up.
Varun walked away.



He didn't know where he was going.
His chest felt heavy.
His eyes felt wet.

He reached a nearby park and sat on a bench.

People passed by him.
Laughing.
Talking.

But Varun felt invisible.
Tears rolled down his face.
He didn't wipe them.
He didn't hide them.

After a while, someone sat beside him.

A calm voice spoke,
"Are you okay, boy?"

Varun stayed silent.

Then he laugh softly and say,
"I don't know."

The old man waited.

Varun continue,
"I loved someone. Today, I told her. She said I'm only a friend."

The old man nod slowly and ask,
"First love?"

Varun nodded.

The old man say quietly,
"Life always has other plans."

Varun laugh bitterly.
He say,
"If this is life's plan, it's a bad one. Everything in my life goes wrong."

The old man looked at him carefully.
He say,
"You keep everything inside. You don't talk about your pain."

Varun looked down.
He say,
"I can't. If I tell my mother, she will worry. My father won't understand. My friends will make it a joke."

The old man stayed silent.
He listened.

Varun take a deep breath and say,
"I lost my dreams. I work every day, but I don't like this life. I don't have time to live. I don't even know why I'm running."

After a pause, he whisper,
"I don't like this life. Why is life like this for me? Do you know what life is?"

The old man looked at the sky.
He didn't answer yet.

Night slowly covered the park.



Chapter 5 – What Is Life

The old man stayed quiet for a moment.

Varun waited.

The park was calm.
Only the sound of wind moving through the trees.

Finally, the old man spoke,
"Life doesn't move in one straight line. Sometimes it gives. Sometimes it takes away."

Varun looked at the ground.
He whisper,
"I did everything right. I studied. I worked. I adjusted. Still... I lost my dreams. I lost the person I loved."

The old man nod slowly.
He say,
"Life has two sides. One is what we expect. The other is what actually happens."

Varun ask softly,
"How do I forgive people... even when they hurt me?"
He add quietly,
"And how do I forget someone I loved?"

The old man smile gently.
He say,
"Think of water. You don't fight with it. You let it flow away. Forgiveness is the same. Not for them... for your peace."

Varun stayed quiet.
For the first time, his chest felt a little light.

At that moment, Varun's phone rang.

It was Priya.

She say,
"Varun, I'm really sorry. I thought a lot after you left."
"I think... I also love you."

Varun's eyes widened.

She ask,
"Can you come to the coffee shop?"

Varun smiled.
He say quickly,
"Yes, I'll come. Just a few minutes."

He look at the old man and say,
"Thank you, sir. Thank you for listening."

Without waiting, he ran out of the park.



The old man stayed on the bench.
He looked up at the sky.
The night was calm, quiet, perfect.

Suddenly, he heard a little baby laughing.

He turned.

A small child sat nearby, smiling without reason.
Pure.
Happy.

The old man smile softly and whisper,
"This... this is pure happiness. This is pure life."

After a while, Varun returned.

He looked at the old man.
He ask,
"Hello sir... you are still here?"

The old man smile softly and say,
"I'm watching the sky."

Varun smile a little and say,
"Oohh... okay sir. Okay... what is your name?"

The old man look at him and say,
"My name is Gopinath."

Varun nodded.
He didn't need more words.

Life begins with dreams.
Life breaks us.
Life teaches us.
And sometimes...
life answers with a simple smile.



Life

Life has two sides:
what we expect,
and what actually happens.

We dream with open eyes,
but life answers quietly.

Yesterday is gone,
tomorrow is unknown.
Life is only now—
this moment, this breath.

If we are happy,
that is the true meaning of life.

by :
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